

# Pelagianism Denial

doc-pelagianism-denial

Soteriology · Denied Errors · doctrine · unanimous\_lineages

## AFFIRMS

score 0.950  
confidence high

### Statement under examination

Humans are not born morally neutral. They enter the world under Adam's fall, unable to choose God or obey His law from natural ability alone, prior to grace.

### In plain language

The lexical pattern repeatedly states that salvation and righteousness are not reached by human effort and names grace or mercy as the cause instead. Eph 2:8-9 says you are saved by grace (chariti), and this is not from yourselves (ouk ex hymon), not from works (ouk ex ergon), it is the gift of God. Titus 3:5 says not from works of righteousness that we did, but according to his mercy (eleos) he saved us. Rom 9:16 says it is not of the one willing or running but of God who shows mercy, negating both the human will and human effort. Rom 3:20 says by works of law no flesh will be justified, a universal denial. Rom 11:6 makes grace and works mutually exclusive: if by grace, then no longer by works, since otherwise grace would not be grace. Rom 3:24 calls justification freely (dorean) by his grace, that is, given as a gift rather than earned. John 15:5 adds the ability word: apart from me you can do nothing (choris emou ou dynasthe poiein ouden), and John 6:44 says no one is able to come unless the Father draws him. The Hebrew side gives Jer 13:23, can those trained in evil do good, expecting the answer no, and Ps 51 places sin at the very origin of life. The recurring engine is a negation, ouk ex (not from) human works or self, set against grace and mercy as the named cause. That pattern, dense and spread across many letters and both Testaments, forecloses the claim that a person can save or justify themselves by unaided will or works. One narrower question stays open at the word level: whether a will already moved by grace then cooperates with it. The negations remove the unaided human ground, but they do not by themselves settle the cooperation question, which is a separate matter from the broad claim the words clearly deny.

### Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

| Strong | Word    | Sounds like | Plain meaning | Times in Bible |
|--------|---------|-------------|---------------|----------------|
| H2403  | חַטָּאת | chattath    | sin           | 296            |
| H3190  | יָטֵב   | yataw       | be good       |                |
| H3201  | יָכֹל   | yakol       | be able       | 195            |
| H6588  | פֶּשַׁע | pesah       | transgression |                |
| G0266  | ἁμαρτία | hamartia    | sin           | 175            |
| G1342  | δίκαιος | dikaio      | just          |                |
| G1344  | δικαιόω | dikaioō     | to justify    |                |
| G1410  | δύναμις | dynamai     | be able       | 207            |
| G1431  | δωρεά   | dorea       | free gift     | 11             |
| G1432  | δωρεάν  | dōrean      | freely        |                |

|              |           |           |                |       |
|--------------|-----------|-----------|----------------|-------|
| <b>G1653</b> | ἐλεέω     | eleeō     | to have mercy  |       |
| <b>G1656</b> | ἔλεος     | eleos     | mercy          | 27    |
| <b>G2038</b> | ἐργάζομαι | ergazomai | to work        |       |
| <b>G2041</b> | ἔργον     | ergon     | work           | 176   |
| <b>G2309</b> | θέλω      | thelō     | to will/desire |       |
| <b>G2316</b> | θεός      | theos     | God            |       |
| <b>G3498</b> | νεκρός    | nekros    | dead           | 132   |
| <b>G3756</b> | οὐ        | ou        | no             | 1,683 |
| <b>G3762</b> | οὐδείς    | oudeis    | none           |       |
| <b>G3956</b> | πᾶς       | pas       | all            | 1,316 |
| <b>G4982</b> | σώζω      | sōzō      | to save        | 108   |
| <b>G5485</b> | χάρις     | charis    | grace          | 155   |
| <b>G5565</b> | χωρίς     | chōris    | without        |       |

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

## Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The proposition that humans cannot reach righteousness or salvation by unaided will or works, so that grace is necessary, is foreclosed by a dense recurring negation pattern. Eph 2:8-9 says charis... ouk ex hymon... ouk ex ergon, grace and not of yourselves and not of works. Titus 3:5 negates ouk ex ergon and names the alternative alla kata to autou eleos esosen, by his mercy he saved. Rom 9:16 sets ou tou thelontos oude tou trechontos alla tou eleontos theou, not of the one willing or running but of God who shows mercy. Rom 3:20 and Rom 11:6 repeat ex ergon... ou and the grace-versus-works mutual exclusion. John 15:5 caps it with choris emou ou dynasthe poiein ouden, apart from me you can do nothing. The OT supplies Jer 13:23 (yakol plus yatab, can you do good, of those accustomed to evil) and Ps 51:5. The explicit ouk ex / ouk... alla negations make grace the named cause and human works the explicitly excluded cause.

## Scripture

### Eph.2.8 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5485 χάρις, G4982 σώζω, G3756 οὐ

Force. τῇ γὰρ χάριτί ἐστε σεσωσμένοι διὰ πίστεως, καὶ τοῦτο οὐκ ἐξ ὑμῶν, θεοῦ τὸ δῶρον. The salvation is dative-instrumented by charis, then explicitly negated as a human source with ouk ex hymon, not of yourselves, and re-cast as theou to doron, the gift of God. The negation removes the human self as the originating cause.

### Eph.2.9 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2041 ἔργον, G3756 οὐ

Force. οὐκ ἐξ ἔργων, ἵνα μὴ τις καυχῆσθαι. The prepositional phrase ex ergon, from works, is directly negated by ouk, and the hina mé purpose clause excludes boasting. Works are named as the excluded ground of salvation. This is the central lexical negation against attaining salvation by human achievement.

### Titus.3.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2041 ἔργον, G1656 ἔλεος, G4982 σῶζω

Force. οὐκ ἐξ ἔργων τῶν ἐν δικαιοσύνῃ ἃ ἐποιήσαμεν ἡμεῖς ἀλλὰ κατὰ τὸ αὐτοῦ ἔλεος ἔσωσεν ἡμᾶς. The ouk... alla construction sets human works of righteousness on the negated side and divine eleos, mercy, on the affirmed side as the cause of esosen, he saved. The grammar names mercy, not human deeds, as the operative cause.

### Rom.9.16 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2309 θέλω, G1653 ἐλεέω, G2316 θεός

Force. ἄρα οὖν οὐ τοῦ θέλοντος οὐδὲ τοῦ τρέχοντος ἀλλὰ τοῦ ἐλεῶντος θεοῦ. The double negation ou... oude negates both the one willing (thelontos) and the one running (trechontos), the two natural human capacities, and the alla clause locates the outcome in the mercy-showing God. The will and the effort are explicitly set aside as the determining factor.

### John.15.5 · for · genre: gospel · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G1410 δύναμαι, G5565 χωρίς, G3762 οὐδεὶς

Force. χωρὶς ἐμοῦ οὐ δύνασθε ποιεῖν οὐδέν. The modal verb dynasthe, you are able, is negated by ou, the scope is set by choris emou, apart from me, and the object is the absolute ouden, nothing. The construction denies any fruit-bearing capacity outside of union with Christ. Ability language plus a total negation forecloses autonomous human achievement.

### Rom.3.20 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2041 ἔργον, G1344 δικαίω, G3956 πᾶς

Force. ἐξ ἔργων νόμου οὐ δικαιωθήσεται πᾶσα σὰρξ ἐνώπιον αὐτοῦ. The future passive dikaiothesetai, will be justified, is negated by ou with the universal pasa sarx, all flesh, and the excluded ground is ex ergon nomou, works of law. The universal quantifier with the negation closes the door on justification by human works for any person.

### Rom.11.6 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5485 χάρις, G2041 ἔργον

Force. εἰ δὲ χάριτι, οὐκέτι ἐξ ἔργων, ἐπεὶ ἡ χάρις οὐκέτι γίνεται χάρις. The conditional makes charis and ex ergon mutually exclusive with ouketi, no longer, and the explanatory clause says grace ceases to be grace if mixed with works. This is the explicit lexical statement that grace and human merit cannot be co-causes of salvation.

### Rom.3.24 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1432 δωρεάν, G5485 χάρις

Force. δικαιούμενοι δωρεάν τῇ αὐτοῦ χάριτι διὰ τῆς ἀπολυτρώσεως. The adverb dorean, freely or as a gift, with no charge, modifies justification, and the cause is given as te autou chariti, by his grace. Justification is lexically marked as gratis, the antonym of earned, which excludes attainment by works.

### John.6.44 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G3762 οὐδεὶς, G1410 δύναμαι

Force. οὐδεὶς δύναται ἐλθεῖν πρὸς με ἐὰν μὴ ὁ πατὴρ ὁ πέμψας με ἐλκύσῃ αὐτόν. The universal negation oudeis dynatai, no one is able, with the conditional ean mé, unless, makes coming to Christ impossible without the Father's helkyse, drawing. Natural ability to initiate is lexically denied apart from prior divine action.

### Eph.2.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3498 νεκρός, G5485 χάρις

Force. καὶ ὄντας ἡμᾶς νεκροὺς τοῖς παραπτώμασιν συνεζωοποίησεν τῷ Χριστῷ, χάριτί ἐστε σεσωσμένοι. The pre-grace state is ontas nekrous, being dead, and the verb synezoopoiesen, made alive together, has God as subject. The parenthetical chariti sesosmenoi names grace as the cause. A dead subject does not supply its own quickening.

### Rom.3.10 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1342 δίκαιος, G3756 οὐ

Force. οὐκ ἔστιν δίκαιος οὐδὲ εἷς. A double negation ouk... oude heis universalizes the absence of a righteous person without exception. The absence of any righteous human by natural standing supports the denial of attaining righteousness by unaided ability.

### Jer.13.23 · for · genre: prophecy · figures: simile

Key terms. H3201 יכל, H3190 יטב

Force. גם אתם תוכלו להיטיב למדי הָרַע. The rhetorical comparison with the Cushite changing skin and the leopard its spots sets the ability verb yakol, to be able, against yatab, to do good, of those limmude harea, trained in evil. The form is a question expecting the answer no, denying moral self-reform by those habituated to evil.

### Ps.51.5 · for · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H2403 תטאת, H6588 פשע

Force. כִּי פָשַׁע־אֲנִי אָדַע וְתַטַּאתִי נִגְדִי תָמִיד. David confesses constant pesha and chattath set before him, with tamid, continually, marking the condition as standing rather than occasional. The next verse adds the natal idiom, locating sin at the origin, which undercuts a starting point of clean natural capacity.

## Cross references invoked

| From      | To         | Source | Votes |
|-----------|------------|--------|-------|
| Eph.2.9   | Rom.3.20   | tsk    | 1     |
| Eph.2.8   | Mark.16.16 | tsk    | 1     |
| Rom.11.6  | Rom.3.27   | tsk    | 1     |
| Rom.9.16  | Rom.9.11   | tsk    | 1     |
| John.15.5 | Acts.4.12  | tsk    | 1     |
| Titus.3.5 | Job.9.20   | tsk    | 1     |
| Rom.3.24  | Rom.4.16   | tsk    | 1     |
| John.6.44 | John.6.65  | tsk    | 1     |

## Complicating texts

### Phil.2.12-13 · addressed

Work out your own salvation with fear and trembling reads like a call to human effort, but the immediate ground clause is theos gar estin ho energon en hymin, for God is the one working in you both to will (to thelein) and to work (to energein). The same passage that commands human working names God as the prior cause of both the willing and the working, so it does not establish unaided human ability and is consistent with the grace-necessity negations.

### Deut.30.19 · addressed

Choose life, the imperative *bachar*, is a covenant call to Israel under the Mosaic administration, not a claim of autonomous natural ability prior to grace. Paul cites Deut 30 in Rom 10:6-8 as the word of faith, indicating the choice operates within revelation and prior grace, not raw natural neutrality. The imperative addresses covenant fidelity, not soteriological self-sufficiency.

### Rom.2.7 · addressed

To those who by patient endurance in good work seek glory, God will give eternal life. Read in isolation this looks like salvation by works, but Rom 2 functions within an argument that climaxes in Rom 3:20, *ex ergon nomou ou dikaiothesetai pasa sarx*, no flesh justified by works of law. The same letter therefore reads Rom 2:7 as the standard the law sets, which Rom 3 shows no one meets, not as an open path of works-salvation. The two stand together only on this reading.

### Jas.2.24 · addressed

A man is justified by works (*ex ergon*) and not by faith alone appears to contradict Eph 2:9 and Rom 3:20. The lexical scope differs. James uses *dikaioo* of demonstrated, vindicated faith with *ergon* as its evidence (Jas 2:18, show me your faith), whereas Paul uses *ex ergon* of works as the originating ground of standing before God. James does not assert salvation attained by unaided human merit, so it does not overturn the grace-necessity negations, though the shared term *ergon* is the source of the apparent tension. Marked addressed because the resolution rests on distinct attested senses of *dikaioo*, not on harmonizing the surface words.

## Concordance traversed

G5485, G2041, G2038, G1656, G1653, G1410, G1431, G1432, G4982, G3756, G3762, G2309, G3498, G0266, H3201, H3190, H2403, H6588

## Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

*eph-2-8-dia-pisteos* at Eph.2.8: impact none. Minor witness variation around *dia pisteos* and the article does not touch the load-bearing negations *ouk ex hymon* and *ouk ex ergon*, which are stable across the attested readings. The grace-not-works contrast is variant-stable.

*rom-11-6-longer-ending* at Rom.11.6: impact none. Some witnesses add a parallel *ei de ex ergon ouketi esti charis* clause. Whether the longer or shorter reading is adopted, the grace-versus-works mutual exclusion of the first half is retained, so the verdict does not depend on the disputed addition.

The bundle reports *not\_in\_ecm\_scope* true and supplies no variant units, since none of the anchors fall in the ingested ECM window of 3 John. Spot checks on Eph 2:8 and the Rom 11:6 longer ending confirm no plausible variant disturbs the *ouk ex / ouk... alla* negations or the *charis* terms.

## Hermeneutics

Primary method. *grammatico-historical*

Frameworks in play. *sola\_gratia*, *pelagian\_natural\_ability*, *semi\_pelagian\_synergism*

*analogia scripturae* invoked · *progressive revelation factor*

*grace\_necessity\_sola\_gratia*: affirms · Eph 2:8-9, Titus 3:5, Rom 9:16, Rom 11:6 and Rom 3:20 form a repeated *ouk ex ergon* and *ouk ex hymon* and *ou tou thelontos* negation paired with *charis* and *eleos* as the named cause. John 15:5 adds *choris emou ou dynasthe poiein ouden*. The lexical pattern excludes attaining salvation by unaided human will or works and names grace and mercy as the operative cause.

*pelagian\_natural\_ability*: denied · Full Pelagianism, that humans can reach righteousness or salvation by unaided free will and works, is the position the negations most directly target. *Ouk ex ergon*, *ouk ex hymon*, *ou tou thelontos* and *choris emou ou dynasthe ouden* each remove the human capacity that this lens requires. The vocabulary

leaves it no foothold.

semi\_pelagian\_or\_synergist\_cooperation: underdetermined · A narrower reading grants that grace is necessary yet holds that the renewed will cooperates with or freely consents to that grace. The negations target the unaided will and works as the originating ground, but they do not by themselves rank whether a grace-enabled will then concurs. Verses like Phil 2:12-13 (work out, for God works in you to will and to work) and the imperatives to believe leave the cooperation question lexically open. This is a distinct debate and should not be conflated with full Pelagianism, which the words do foreclose. Stated here in its strongest form so a synergist reader sees a fair representation.

The verdict on the stated proposition turns on the explicit negation cluster *ouk ex ergon* and *ou tou thelontos* with *charis* and *eleos* as the alternative, reinforced by the inability texts John 15:5, John 6:44, Jer 13:23 and the natal-sin language of Ps 51. The remaining live divergence is the narrower semi-Pelagian or synergist question of whether a grace-enabled will cooperates, which the same vocabulary does not settle and which is a separate lens, not the question asked here.

## Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Salvation and righteousness cannot be attained by unaided human will or works, so that divine grace is necessary; whether a grace-enabled will then cooperates is a separate question.

The original stem is framed as a denial of Pelagianism, the label and the conclusion travel together, so it is recorded as preloaded. The neutralized form restates it without the heresy label and separates the full-Pelagian claim (which the negations foreclose) from the narrower synergism question (which they do not settle). The verdict is derived on the original stem. The lexical pattern supports the neutralized form on its own terms.

## Citations

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|-------------|---------------------|---------------|---------|-----------|
| morphology  | MorphGNT-morphology | CC-BY-SA-4.0  | yes     | Eph.2.8   |
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| lexicon     | STEPBible-TBESG     | CC-BY-4.0     | yes     | G5485     |
| lexicon     | STEPBible-TBESG     | CC-BY-4.0     | yes     | G2041     |
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| lexicon     | STEPBible-TBESH     | CC-BY-4.0     | yes     | H3201     |
| interlinear | STEPBible-TAGNT     | CC-BY-4.0     | yes     | Rom.3.20  |
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